



Origins of Opportunity, Part 1: The Formation of CSWE's Minority Research Fellowship Program, 1954–1978

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ABSTRACT

This paper marks the 50th anniversary of the Council on Social Work Education's (CSWE) Minority Fellowship Program (MFP), exploring its historical development. Leveraging archival CSWE materials, it chronicles pivotal events from 1954 leading to the MFP's inception in 1973 and its early research fellowship cohorts through 1978. This historical analysis examines the advocacy, challenges, and milestones within the CSWE and broader social movements that promoted diversity and inclusion in social work education. The MFP specifically addressed the underrepresentation of minorities by developing culturally attuned researchers and practitioners. This reflective examination enriches the social work historical record and underscores the MFP's transformative impact in creating a profession that effectively reflects and serves our racially and ethnically diverse society.

ARTICLE HISTORY

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The Council on Social Work Education's (CSWE) Minority Fellowship Program (MFP) was conceived as a beacon of change amid the stark underrepresentation of racial minorities in social work education, aiming to reflect the rich diversity of the communities it serves. Established in 1973, the MFP aimed to develop an educational framework that was both inclusive and dynamic—an especially challenging task given the 20 years of systemic racism and discrimination that had persisted since CSWE's founding in 1952. Throughout the 1950s to the 1970s, despite a commitment to social justice, social work leaders faced significant challenges in addressing racism and discrimination within the profession. Historical records indicate persistent systemic biases and institutional barriers that hindered effective service to diverse populations (Harty et al., 2024; Miller, 1969). The underrepresentation of minorities in social work educational programs (Francis, 1973; Juliette, 1973; Mackey, 1973; Miranda, 1973; Mutase, 1973), the lack of culturally relevant curricula (Gary, 1974; Norton, 1978; Scott, 1970), and inadequate support for minority social workers and communities (Longres, 1972; Penketh, 2000; Trolander, 1997; Wainwright, 2009) underscore these challenges.

This article meticulously traces the origins and development of the MFP, beginning with pivotal events from 1954 that culminated in its establishment in 1973, and continuing through to its third research fellowship cohort in 1978, just before the introduction of the second clinical fellowship. Coinciding with the 50th anniversary of the MFP Research Fellowship, this exploration is particularly timely, offering a moment to reflect on how historical advocacy and structural changes have enriched social work education for students of color. This comprehensive narrative sets the stage for understanding the MFP's role in fostering a more equitable social work profession, underscoring its ongoing role in enhancing diversity and supporting students of color who serve racially and ethnically diverse populations.

Enhancing the historical record of the CSWE MFP

Despite the significance of the MFP in enhancing diversity within social work education, only some studies have examined its history. In 1996, the *Journal of Social Work Education (JSWE)* published a study by Jerome H. Schiele and E. Aracelis Francis examining the career progress of ethnic minority social work faculty who were previously MFP fellows. Surveying 90 former fellows, the research documented their academic ranks, tenure status, and success in promotions and publications, revealing notable disparities in achievement based on ethnicity and gender. The study found that Hispanic American¹ faculty members were likelier to be full professors and hold tenure than their African American, Asian American, and Native American peers, with men generally achieving tenure more frequently than women. Although not focused solely on historical aspects, the article provides valuable historical insights into the MFP and records its fellows' professional achievements and challenges in academia (Schiele & Francis, 1996).

In 2005, Pinto and Francis published a study of MFP's role in supporting the professional growth of racial and ethnic minority scholars. It outlines how the MFP's instrumental and social support facilitates scholars' focus on full-time doctoral studies, enhancing their academic and research capabilities through a supportive network. This study significantly contributes to the MFP's history by providing a theoretical framework that explains the program's effectiveness in boosting the representation of minorities in leadership roles within academia and social services, promoting a more inclusive social work academic community (Pinto & Francis, 2005). In 2007, *JSWE* released a special issue featuring articles written by former scholars of the MFP. The special issue was dedicated to E. Aracelis Francis, recognizing her role as the second director of the MFP, taking over from Carl A. Scott in 1986 and serving until her retirement in 2007 (Roberts & Jackson, 2007). While this special issue marked a significant historical moment commemorating the contribution of an essential figure in MFP history, none of the articles featured in the issue specifically focused on the MFP itself.

Considering the limited literature specifically chronicling the history of the MFP, this article serves as a foundational account of the historical developments that led to the establishment of the CSWE MFP. Drawing on a wealth of archival materials from the University of Minnesota Social Welfare History Archives, the Internet Archive, and HathiTrust, the article meticulously outlines the events from 1954 to 1978. It underscores the growing recognition of the need for inclusion and diversity within social work education, detailing the initiatives that set the stage for the MFP. This historical analysis delves into the crucial periods that shaped the program, providing detailed context for understanding its origins and influence on the profession.

Key events leading to the establishment of the MFP

The Civil Rights Era of the 1950s and 1960s, marked by significant struggles for equality, reached a peak with the assassination of Dr. Martin Luther King, Jr., in 1968, highlighting severe racial inequalities in the United States and the need for systemic change. Concurrently, the Black Power Movement, advocating for racial pride and economic empowerment, adopted a militant stance, demanding autonomy for Black communities (Gary, 1974; Norton, 1978; Scott, 1970). The Kerner Commission Report of 1968 emphasized the nation's division into "two societies, one black, one white—separate and unequal," and called for substantial reforms to support Black communities and address systemic inequalities (National Advisory Commission on Civil Disorders, 1968). This period also saw activism from other groups: the American Indian Movement addressed sovereignty and injustices

¹In this article, the authors use racial and ethnic terms as they appear in the archival documents and historical texts consulted. Terms associated with Asian, Black, Indigenous, Latinx, and Hispanic populations have varied over time and held different meanings. Similarly, the historical use of the term "minority" compared to the contemporary use of the term "minoritized" has evolved. To maintain historical accuracy, the original terms used in these archival sources have been preserved. The authors recognize that some terms are still in use today, while others may now be considered outdated or inappropriate. The intention is to preserve the historical context of these documents while acknowledging the evolving nature of language and cultural identity.

Table 1. Timeline of key events surrounding the establishment of CSWE’s MFP.

1950–60s	1970s
'54: Standard 1234 on discrimination	'70: Commission on Minority Groups
'67: Howard University Institute	'72: Ethnic Minority Task Forces
'69: Caucuses demands to delegates	'73: NIMH Minority Group Mental Health
'69: Standard 1234A on diversity	'74: NIMH Minority Fellowship Program
'69: Special Committee on Minority Groups	'75: CSWE Minority Fellowship Program
'69: Black psychiatrists meet with NIMH	'78: NIMH Minority Fellowship Evaluation

Note. CSWE = Council on Social Work Education; MFP = Minority Fellowship Program; NIMH = National Institute of Mental Health.

faced by Native Americans (Smith & Warrior, 1996), the Chicano Movement fought for land rights and educational reform (Muñoz, 2007), the Asian American Political Alliance pushed for civil rights and antiwar efforts (Wei, 2010), and the Young Lords evolved from a Puerto Rican nationalist group into an organization advocating for social justice and neighborhood empowerment (Enck-Wanzer, 2010).

In response to the persistent issues of racism and colonialism within the social work profession, the CSWE took several significant steps to address these systemic barriers: updating accreditation standards, hosting cutting-edge initiatives, and creating task forces, committees, and caucuses—all leading to the ultimate creation of the MFP itself. CSWE’s MFP was created to support minority students and enhance inclusivity and diversity within the profession. The MFP emerged as a critical strategy in addressing the underrepresentation of minority groups in social work, providing financial support, and fostering an educational environment that values and integrates diverse perspectives (Lodge, 1977; Scott, 1976). To understand CSWE’s MFP, reviewing the critical developments between 1954 and 1972 is crucial. Table 1 outlines key events leading to the establishment of the CSWE MFP, as discussed in this section, and subsequent developments explored in the following section.

Accreditation Standards 1234 and 1234A

The introduction of CSWE’s Accreditation Standards 1234 and 1234A marked the beginning of these efforts to address discrimination and the lack of racial and cultural diversity in social work education. In 1954, the same year *Brown v. Board of Education* declared public school segregation unconstitutional, the CSWE Commission on Accreditation implemented Standard 1234, requiring nondiscriminatory practices in social work education. This standard, detailed in the Accrediting Standards manual, required that social work programs operate without discrimination based on race, color, creed, or ethnic origin in all facets, including student selection and admissions. Despite its progressive intentions, by the late 1950s and early 1960s, there was scant evidence to demonstrate the standard’s effectiveness, primarily due to infrequent reevaluations of social work schools, typically every 10 years (CSWE, 1974; CSWE Board of Directors Meeting, 1968). In response to the limited data on compliance with Standard 1234, the Commission on Accreditation conducted a survey in 1968 to assess adherence to the nondiscrimination standard among all accredited and prospective accredited social work schools in the United States. All 64 accredited institutions participated. While no schools reported violations of Standard 1234, there was significant variation in the extent of proactive measures taken to enhance social and cultural diversity within student bodies, faculty, and staff. Furthermore, schools differed in their efforts to offer opportunities to educationally disadvantaged students (Reichert, 1968, 1970).

A critical aspect of the survey involved identifying challenges in enrolling minority students. Among 61 schools surveyed, 39 cited a shortage of qualified minority-group applicants as the most significant challenge. Financial constraints were also notable, with 11 schools each identifying a lack of funding for support and remedial programs as substantial issues. Additionally, concerns like institutional rigidity and high attrition rates among minority students highlighted ongoing difficulties in creating inclusive educational environments (Reichert, 1968, 1970). The insights gained from the 1968

survey on Standard 1234 prompted the Commission on Accreditation to propose a new, more proactive standard. Recognizing the need to support and encourage schools to enhance racial and cultural diversity actively, the commission recommended the creation of a new standard in June 1968. This led to the establishment of Standard 1234A in 1969 under the leadership of Carl A. Scott and James Dumpson (CSWE, 1972). This new standard required schools to demonstrate nondiscrimination and show evidence of special efforts to ensure cultural diversity within their programs. Specifically, Standard 1234A mandated that schools should enrich their programs by promoting racial and cultural diversity in their student bodies, faculties, and staff (Edwards, 1979). This initiative marked a significant shift from prohibiting discrimination to actively fostering an inclusive educational environment. While these new accreditation standards promoted nondiscriminatory practices, barriers persisted.

Howard University's collaborative institute

In 1967, Howard University School of Social Work hosted a significant 10-day grant-funded institute focused on enhancing opportunities for educationally disadvantaged students in social work education (Social Work Education Reporter, 1967a). The event was a collaborative effort with CSWE and led by Dr. Mary Ella Robertson, then chair of the CSWE Committee on Admissions. The institute aimed to develop effective recruitment and selection strategies for students with high potential but insufficient academic preparation, determine their educational needs, and design programs that would ensure their success in graduate studies. Attended by representatives from 20 graduate schools and several national agencies, the institute sought to foster school leadership in implementing its action proposals. The outcomes were intended to be published in a special monograph and discussed at the 1968 CSWE Annual Program Meeting (Social Work Education Reporter, 1967b).

Carl A. Scott's first initiatives as director of special projects and research

Following the 1967 Howard University Institute, significant developments occurred within CSWE to support educationally disadvantaged and ethnic minority students in graduate social work programs. Carl A. Scott, appointed director of special projects and research at CSWE, played a pivotal role in these initiatives, leveraging insights from the institute to formulate targeted programs. The outcomes from the institute were discussed at the CSWE Annual Program Meeting in January 1968, leading to the development of "Proposed Models for Opening and Expanding Opportunities for Educationally Disadvantaged Students in Graduate Social Work Education" (CSWE Committee on Students, 1968b).

These models aimed to recruit and support students from racial and ethnic minority groups. Two main proposals were developed. The first proposal, Recruitment and Training of Minority Faculty in Social Work Education, emphasized the recruitment, preparation, and placement of minority group members in faculties of graduate schools of social work. The second proposal, Expanding Opportunities for Disadvantaged and Minority Students, focused on enhancing access and success for students from diverse backgrounds, including African Americans, poor and rural Whites, Native Americans, and Puerto Ricans. The CSWE's Committee on Students formalized these initiatives, with a special task force drafting a detailed proposal approved in early 1968 (CSWE Committee on Students, 1968a).

Advocacy by the House of Delegates driven by student, worker, and educator caucuses

In January 1969, the CSWE House of Delegates meeting became a significant platform for advocacy by three influential groups: the Black Student Caucus, the Caucus of Spanish-Speaking Social Workers, and the Caucus of Black Social Work Educators. These caucuses presented well-defined demands to foster inclusivity and address systemic inequities within social work education. The Black Student Caucus concentrated on strategies to improve the recruitment and support mechanisms for Black

students within social work programs. The Caucus of Spanish-Speaking Social Workers highlighted the need for greater representation and understanding of Spanish-speaking individuals within social work education. Meanwhile, the Caucus of Black Social Work Educators expressed concerns regarding the insufficient use of their professional skills and academic competencies in shaping educational structures. These collective demands at the CSWE House of Delegates meeting underscored a critical moment in the push for more equitable and inclusive social work education practices, reflecting a broader movement toward acknowledging and addressing the needs of diverse communities within the educational framework (CSWE House of Delegates, 1969a).

In April 1969, the CSWE board of directors passed a resolution to address the demands above, reaffirming CSWE's commitment to prioritizing the concerns of ethnic minorities within social work education. It emphasized the necessity of adhering to nondiscrimination standards in accreditation and standard-setting activities, further outlining CSWE's leadership role in promoting the recruitment and support of students and faculty from ethnic minority groups. This resolution highlighted the importance of curriculum enrichment in preparing social workers to address issues relevant to ethnic minorities more effectively (CSWE House of Delegates, 1969b; Social Work Education Reporter, 1969a, 1969b). Ultimately, this resolution led to a significant action: establishing a Special Committee on Minority Groups tasked with guiding and enhancing CSWE's efforts to meet these objectives (Pins, 1969b, 1969a).

Establishing the Special Committee on Minority Groups

In September 1969, CSWE established the Special Committee on Minority Groups to address the growing concerns about inclusivity and diversity within social work education (Social Work Education Reporter, 1969c). Composed of members from various minority groups, including educators, practitioners, and students, the committee guided three critical areas: recruitment of minority students, development of minority faculty, and creation of curriculum materials relevant to ethnic minority groups. The committee aimed to assist CSWE in setting priorities for recruitment and curricular development that catered to the needs of five identified ethnic groups: American Indians, Asian Americans, Blacks, Chicanos, and Puerto Ricans (Scott, 1971).

Throughout 1970, the committee's efforts led to tangible advancements. The committee facilitated consultation services to schools to develop effective minority student recruitment strategies, which resulted in a marked increase in minority student enrollment in graduate social work programs, as reported by CSWE. Additionally, the committee played a vital role in shaping discussions at various educational meetings and sessions focused on minority issues, endorsing the development of specialized resources to aid both faculty and students in understanding and addressing the unique challenges faced by different minority groups. These efforts were underpinned by ongoing consultations and new strategies to recruit and support minority faculty members, showcasing the committee's comprehensive approach to fostering diversity within social work education (Scott, 1971; Special Committee on Minority Groups, 1970).

Transitioning to the Commission on Minority Groups

Despite marked success on behalf of the Special Committee on Minority Groups, the committee itself was experimental, initially formed to guide CSWE on minority student recruitment, faculty development, and curriculum development (Scott, 1971). It was recognized early on that the broad nature of the committee might not effectively meet the specific needs of the diverse groups they intended to serve. Consequently, the special committee was dissolved in June 1970 and transitioned into the new Commission on Minority Groups, established to strategically include diverse groups within social work education (Horner & Borrero, 1981). The new commission was granted the same status as other CSWE commissions, affirming its critical and permanent role. Additionally, a Division on Minority Groups (DMG) was created to replace the existing Unit on Minority Groups, with Carl A. Scott

appointed as its director. This structural enhancement aimed to provide focused and ongoing support to minority group initiatives (Pins, 1970).

The transition from a special committee to the Commission on Minority Groups was driven by the need for tailored strategies to meet the distinct needs of diverse ethnic groups, including Asian Americans, Blacks, Chicanos, Native Americans, and Puerto Ricans. The commission established specific task forces focused on recruitment, curriculum development, and faculty support, aligning efforts with each group's unique challenges (Special Committee on Minority Groups, 1970). Among its key activities, the DMG revised the CSWE Teaching Registration Form to identify social workers who could support minority students and collaborated with the Division of Research on data projects, noting an increase in minority student enrollment from about 15% in 1968 to 20% in 1969. Additionally, the DMG provided consultations on recruitment strategies for ethnic minority students and faculty. It actively addressed minority issues in social work education, emphasizing its commitment to fostering a diverse educational environment (Commission on Minority Groups, 1971; DMG, 1970).

Creation of five ethnic minority task forces

In response to recommendations by the Commission on Minority Groups and input from minority representatives, CSWE established five ethnic minority task forces over 3 years, starting in 1970. These task forces, representing American Indian, Asian American, Black, Chicano, and Puerto Rican communities, aimed to delve deeply into social work education's specific challenges and concerns for their respective groups. By 1972, all task forces were operational, focusing on setting program priorities and devising strategies to address educational issues effectively (Commission on Minority Groups, 1973). Supported by funding from the National Institute of Mental Health (NIMH), the Health Services and Mental Health Administration (HSMHA), and the Department of Health, Education, and Welfare (HEW), these task forces were instrumental in identifying critical problems and suggesting actionable solutions for social work programs and CSWE to implement (Francis, 1973; Juliette, 1973; Mackey, 1973; Miranda, 1973; Mutase, 1973).

In spring 1973, in response to the detailed reports from the five ethnic minority task forces, the CSWE established an ad hoc committee within the Commission on Minority Groups to review the task force's reports and recommend actionable strategies. The committee convened in June 1973, focused on interpreting the diverse insights provided by the task forces into a coherent strategy that schools of social work could implement (Social Work Education Reporter, 1973). After extensive deliberation, this ad hoc committee identified maintaining a high priority on recruitment and development of a model curriculum as needed areas for program development. Finally, they advocated for the inclusion of courses on racism and the experiences of ethnic minority groups in America within the core curriculum of all social work schools, aiming to broaden understanding and improve educational outcomes in social work programs (Social Work Education Reporter, 1973).

Historical linkages

Understanding the historical context leading to the creation of the MFP is crucial for appreciating its significance and foundational purpose. The historical context outlined shows a clear trajectory of growing awareness and action against the systemic barriers that ethnic minorities face in social work education. The advocacy efforts, the structural reforms within CSWE, and the proactive establishment of task forces aimed at inclusivity directly influenced the creation of the MFP. Recognizing this backdrop highlights the MFP's role, not merely as a scholarship program, but as a strategic initiative to cultivate a diverse workforce equipped to address the nuanced needs of all communities. It underscores the commitment to turning past challenges into actionable programs that aim to reduce disparities in the educational landscape and ensure that social work education and practice are as inclusive and effective as possible.

The MFP

This next section will delve into the inception, implementation, and effect of the MFP, which was designed to address the persistent underrepresentation of minorities in social work education and to nurture a new generation of professionals committed to service and research in diverse communities. By exploring the MFP's detailed operations, successes, and areas for improvement, we aim to provide a comprehensive understanding of how this program has shaped the landscape of social work education and contributed to the field's ongoing evolution toward greater inclusivity and equity.

The NIMH MFP

In 1969, led by Black psychiatrists Dr. Chester Pierce and Dr. James Comer at a meeting with NIMH, it was highlighted that NIMH and other federal agencies were ineffective in addressing racism within their operations. This meeting emphasized the necessity for targeted actions to mitigate racial disparities in mental health services and professions (Jones & Austin-Dailey, 2009). This led to two significant proposals: establishing a specialized NIMH unit for minority mental health programs and an Affirmative Action Plan (Jones & Austin-Dailey, 2009; Ochberg & Brown, 1973). In response, NIMH founded the Center for Minority Group Mental Health (Minority Center) in 1971, directed by Dr. James Ralph. The Minority Center aimed to combat institutional racism by analyzing its dynamics in health and human service sectors, assessing its effects on broader populations, and training professionals in antiracism strategies (Carew, 1977).

When the Minority Center was established, it narrowly defined "minorities" to include four groups: American Indians, Asians, Blacks, and Hispanics (Carew, 1977, p. 109). This decision ignited debates about which groups the Minority Center would support (Ochberg & Brown, 1973). Initially led by Black psychiatrists focusing on Black community health, the Minority Center identified Blacks as a primary minority group for support. Subsequently, a consensus was reached to include American Indians, Asians, and Hispanics (e.g., Mexican Americans, Puerto Ricans, and Cubans) recognized for also facing systematic discrimination. However, this broad inclusion raised challenges in effectively catering to diverse groups within a single administrative framework. The central question was whether to develop distinct programs for each group or to manage a unified program, which risked diluting the specific needs of each minority group (Ochberg & Brown, 1973). Another debate centered on which groups the Minority Center would not support. The Minority Center excluded White ethnic minorities and White women from its definition of minority group members. Although these groups reported facing systematic discrimination, the decision to exclude them was pragmatic. Given the Minority Center's limited budget, it prioritized support of racial and non-White ethnic minorities, viewing racism as a more pressing issue than the prejudice experienced by these excluded groups (Ochberg & Brown, 1973).

In 1973, the Minority Center at NIMH launched the MFP using a T32 training grant. This initiative targeted the significant underrepresentation of minority clinicians and researchers in the mental health sector across the four racial and ethnic minority groups (i.e., American Indians, Asians, Blacks, and Hispanics) the Minority Center identified as needing support. The program's objective was to create a comprehensive mental health training framework across key disciplines, thereby enhancing the recruitment and development of minority professionals in both research and clinical practices within the mental health field (Jones & Austin-Dailey, 2009). By 1974, the NIMH MFP was active, granting awards to five key professional associations in mental health disciplines: the American Nurses Association, American Psychiatric Association, American Psychological Association, American Sociological Association, and the CSWE. These organizations created and executed programs that supported doctoral training and cultivated a cadre of minority researchers to enhance mental health research and practice. The primary goal of the NIMH MFP was to foster a solid commitment to research among minority professionals, aiming to develop them into leaders and innovators in mental health research. This intention was reflected in the decision to allocate funding directly to professional associations

instead of universities (Comas-Diaz, 1990). This strategic choice was made to avoid high overhead charges typical of universities and to leverage the prestige of national organizations, which was deemed more appealing to minority applicants. This approach allowed for a more focused and effective use of funds, ensuring the NIMH MFP could achieve its mission of enriching the field with skilled minority researchers dedicated to advancing mental health sciences (Rosen, 1974).

The CSWE Research MFP

The organizational structure of the CSWE Research MFP was intricately woven into the broader framework of the CSWE. Central to this structure was the Commission on Minority Groups, established in 1968, which provided leadership and guidance for developing and implementing policies concerning racial and ethnic minority groups in social work education. Reporting directly to the CSWE board of directors, the commission oversaw the National Selection Committee of the MFP. This committee was responsible for policy implementation and monitoring, including selecting fellows and proposing program adjustments. Carl A. Scott, as the director of the MFP and associate executive director of CSWE, managed the program's daily operations and financial aspects, ensuring the program's alignment with CSWE's strategic goals (Scott, 1976).

The board of directors of the CSWE held substantial responsibility for the governance and strategic direction of the MFP. Each year, the board received detailed reports on the MFP's progress and activities, directly influencing its ongoing development and ensuring alignment with broader educational objectives. The board's composition included members appointed by the CSWE president, prominently featuring Dr. James R. Dumpson, a former dean of Fordham University's Graduate School of Social Work, who was a key Black leader on the board. From 1974 to 1977, the MFP board of 37 people saw variations in the number of minority members, starting with nine minority members in 1974–1975, increasing to 12 in 1975–1976, and returning to nine in 1976–1977 (Lodge, 1977). Additionally, minority representatives played a crucial role in the overall operations of the CSWE beyond the MFP. Policies and practices ensured significant minority representation at various organizational levels, including the House of Delegates. Each major minority group was guaranteed a minimum of three representatives, with further opportunities for election in other categories like faculty and deans of schools of social work. This structured approach to inclusion extended to all commissions, committees, task forces, ad hoc committees, and the board of directors. Appointments made by the CSWE president were scrutinized to ensure diversity, and the nomination process for elected positions was designed to secure adequate minority representation. These efforts were bolstered by the activities of the Commission on Minority Groups, which played a central role in promoting and facilitating minority participation across the organization (Lodge, 1977).

Recruitment of fellows

Recruitment for the CSWE MFP involved a comprehensive dissemination of information through brochures and flyers, which were sent to all schools of social work, undergraduate programs in social work, members of CSWE, and related social work organizations. Additionally, racial and ethnic newspapers and organizations were engaged to reach potential fellows. The National Selection Committee, consisting of racially and ethnically diverse representatives, played a crucial role as recruiters and conduits of information on the MFP. Furthermore, deans of graduate schools and directors of doctoral programs also helped alert potential applicants to the fellowship's existence and encouraged prospective fellows to apply (Lodge, 1977).

The research and clinical fellowships

The CSWE MFP provided two distinct fellowships: a research-focused fellowship aimed at supporting minority students conducting research with ethnic minorities (CSWE MFP Research Fellowship) and a clinical-focused fellowship designed to prepare minority students for leadership roles in mental health involving ethnic minorities (CSWE MFP Clinical Fellowship; Social Work Education Reporter, 1979). The two CSWE MFPs were funded by NIMH's Minority Center programs (Social Work Education Reporter, 1979). Specifically, the CSWE MFP Research Fellowship first received funding through the NIMH Minority Center under HSMHA of the HEW. Meanwhile, the CSWE MFP Clinical Fellowship was initially supported by the NIMH Minority Center under the auspices of the Alcohol, Drug Abuse, and Mental Health Administration of HEW (Marquis Who's Who, 1976; 1978; Brown & Okura, 1995; Wohlford, 1991).

These fellowships aimed to support social work students in minority groups designated by the NIMH Minority Center, including American Indians, Asians, Blacks, and Hispanics (i.e., Chicanos and Puerto Ricans; Penick, 1978). The CSWE MFP Research Fellowship, funded in 1974, which began its first cohort in 1975, commemorates its 50th anniversary in 2024. Officially known as the "Doctoral Fellowship Program for Ethnic Minority Students Specializing in Research Relevant to Ethnic Minorities," the CSWE MFP Research Fellowship offered fellowships to minority social work master's students pursuing doctoral research degrees (Social Work Education Reporter, 1978, p. 3). The CSWE MFP Clinical Fellowship was funded in 1978 and had its first cohort in 1979. Formally titled the "Doctoral Fellowship Program for Ethnic Minority Students Preparing for Leadership Roles in the Field of Mental Health," the CSWE MFP Clinical Fellowship offered fellowships to minority social work doctoral students preparing for leadership roles in mental health (Schiele & Francis, 1996; Social Work Education Reporter, 1978, p. 3; 1979).

It is essential to distinguish the timelines of the CSWE MFP from the broader NIMH MFP. The NIMH MFP began its first cohort in 1974–1975. In contrast, the CSWE initiated its CSWE MFP Research Fellowship with the first cohort in 1975–1976, followed by the second in 1976–1977, and the third in 1977–1978. The following section focuses on the first three CSWE MFP Research Fellowship cohorts from 1975–1978, preceding the first CSWE MFP Clinical Fellowship cohort in 1979. Additionally, the first two CSWE MFP Research Fellowship cohorts (1975–1977) were examined in a 1978 NIMH-funded evaluation that analyzed the first three cohorts of the broader NIMH MFP from 1974–1977. The findings of this evaluation will be discussed later in the article.

The first three cohorts

In its inaugural cohort (1975–1976), the CSWE MFP Research Fellowship awarded fellowships to 15 minority students pursuing degrees in social work. These recipients were selected from 169 applicants and evaluated based on their potential for Indigenous research, commitment to social work, and involvement within their ethnic minority communities. As displayed in Table 2, the 1975–1976 cohort included 13 fellows entering doctoral programs in social work and two students entering Master of Social Work (MSW) programs (Social Work Education Reporter, 1975). Notably, the two MSW awards were specifically granted to Native American students due to this group's low number of doctoral applications (Commission on Minority Groups, 1975).

In the second year (1976–1977) of the CSWE MFP Research Fellowship, 15 new fellowships were awarded to minority students pursuing doctoral degrees in social work, bringing the total to 30 fellowships distributed over the first 2 years. These recipients were selected from 133 applicants. Details about the new fellows for the 1976–1977 cohort and the institutions they were entering are displayed in Table 3. Additionally, the CSWE MFP renewed second-year fellowships for 13 of the initial 15 fellows from the 1975–1976 cohort (Social Work Education Reporter, 1976).

In the third year (1977–1978) of the CSWE MFP Research Fellowship, 16 new fellowships were awarded, as listed in Table 4. This cohort brought the total to 46 fellowships awarded over 3 years.

Table 2. CSWE MFP Research Fellowship: Cohort One (1975–1976).

Institution	Fellow(s)
University of California Berkeley	Rogers T. Yoshikami
Case Western Reserve	Anita L. Polk
Columbia University	Rodolfo Borrego, Maria M. Correa
University of Denver	Yolanda I. Diaz-Perez, Joseph S. Gallegos, Belva L. Kaulay,* Albert M. Pooley, Margaret Romero Dieppa
Florida State University	Gladys E. Drummond
University of Michigan	Jeremiah P. Cotton
University of Pennsylvania	Kasumi K. Hirayama
University of Southern California	Essie T. Seek
University of Utah	George K. Okazaki, Wilfred Yazzie*

*Seeking Master of Social Work degree.

Note. Compiled from the *Social Work Education Reporter* (1975). CSWE = Council on Social Work Education; MFP = Minority Fellowship Program.

Table 3. CSWE MFP Research Fellowship: Cohort Two (1976–1977).

Institution	Fellow(s)
Brandeis University	Arturo Gonzales, Leon E. Williams
Bryn Mawr College	Nancy Woodruff
University of California, Berkeley	Roberto P. Mejia
Columbia University	William Burgos, Rita Takahashi, Alice P. Lin
University of Denver	Sumiko T. Hennessy, Anthony Lopez, Robert Peck, Elizabeth Scaggs
University of Minnesota–Minneapolis	James T. Shelton
University of Southern California	Roger Delgado
University of Utah	Geraldine Daines
Tulane University	Maria Milagro Lizardi

Note. Compiled from the *Social Work Education Reporter* (1976). CSWE = Council on Social Work Education; MFP = Minority Fellowship Program.

Table 4. CSWE MFP Research Fellowship: Cohort Three (1977–1978).

Institution	Fellow(s)
Adelphi University	Linda Liem
Brandeis University	Eugene D. Lovato, Nellie Tate, Ramiro Valdez
University of California, Berkeley	Theresa K. Cho
Columbia University	Pereta Balian, Philip Jackson
Howard University	Rosalind Griffin, Rubye Nell Johnson
University of Illinois, Chicago	Bageshwari S. Parihar
University of Pennsylvania	John N. Austin, E. Jane Middleton
University of Pittsburgh	Stanley Battle, James Cooper
University of Utah	G. Herbert Grandbois, Kazuye Kumabe

Note. Compiled from the *Social Work Education Reporter* (1977). CSWE = Council on Social Work Education; MFP = Minority Fellowship Program.

Three fellows completed their degrees from the inaugural 1975–1976 cohort—two doctorates and one master’s. Ten additional fellows from this cohort had met their academic requirements and were progressing with their dissertations. All fellows from the second-year (1976–1977) cohort had their fellowships renewed, continuing their studies and research in the program (Social Work Education Reporter, 1977).

The CSWE Minority Fellowship Committee (MFC)

The CSWE MFP MFC was crucial in organizing the MFP, including recruiting fellows, reviewing applications, and determining acceptances (MFC, 1975). In their February 1975 meeting, the MFC made several decisions about the application and review processes. Initial screening was handled by

CSWE staff using criteria such as ethnicity, U.S. residency or citizenship, and educational qualifications, including allowances for exceptional non-MSW applicants. Final selections used a rating system that equally weighed academic and research potential, commitment and involvement in minority communities, and biographical and personal data. The selection process featured blind evaluations to reduce bias and included choosing five alternate candidates for each ethnic group. Financial need was presumed for all, with additional weight in final decisions when finalists had equal merit. Fellowships could be renewed based on academic progress and continued research commitment. Additionally, the committee discussed enhancing support through informal counseling, annual gatherings, and potential collaborations with minority research centers to foster fellows' development (Minority Fellowship Committee, 1975).

In February 1976, the MFC implemented vital policies to improve the MFP's effectiveness (Minority Fellowship National Selection Committee, 1976a). They determined that CSWE fellows failing their comprehensive exams should follow their institutions' appeal procedures, with fellowship continuations influenced by doctoral program recommendations. The committee discouraged transfers between schools, requiring CSWE staff to examine and approve transfer requests as exceptions closely. Unused fellowship funds from discontinued enrollments would roll over to the following year. The fellowship renewal process now includes an application form from the fellow and evaluations from the fellow's faculty advisor and a chosen faculty member. Fellowship support, set at \$3,800 annually, was restricted to four semesters or six quarters, including summer terms, and could be distributed flexibly within a year. Priority was given to new doctoral students and outstanding non-MSW candidates. Last, the committee sought to clarify the "financial need" criterion and address funding gaps for dissertation work, instructing the CSWE to research other programs' practices and consider a funding request for dissertation stages. These changes were designed to streamline operations and support fellows' academic and professional development (Minority Fellowship National Selection Committee, 1976a).

In May 1976, the MFC tackled three significant issues to refine the MFP (Minority Fellowship National Selection Committee, 1976b). First, they decided that financial need should only tip the scales between two equally qualified fellowship candidates. Second, they eliminated dependency allowances, proposing a standardized annual stipend of \$4,000 for doctoral students and \$3,000 for master's students, pending feedback from absent Native American Committee members. Third, to increase fellowship awards, the committee considered negotiating tuition remission with schools and ensuring alignment with NIMH's expectations for schools to commit to the fellowship's goals. They recommended that financial support in the second year be limited to periods of full-time registration, prioritizing new doctoral students. Additionally, fellows must provide proof of full-time enrollment each semester to continue receiving funding. These measures were aimed at streamlining support and enhancing the effectiveness of the fellowship program (Minority Fellowship National Selection Committee, 1976b).

The NIMH MFP evaluation

In 1978, the minority organization L. Miranda Associates, Inc. evaluated the five MFPs sponsored by the NIMH (Penick, 1978). This study, under a contract from the NIMH's Center for Minority Group Mental Health Programs, aimed to understand the representation and quality of minority professionals in mental health fields. The study was also a status check on how the grant of more than \$5 million over 6 years was allocated to the five professional organizations to fund the minority graduate fellowships, including the American Nurses Association (ANA), American Psychiatric Association (APA), American Psychological Association (APSA), American Sociological Association (ASA), and CSWE. The evaluation sought to analyze the structures and operations of these programs, the training quality, the applicants' demographic characteristics, and the fellows' professional growth. Additionally, it examined how these elements influence the overall effect of the five MFPs. This comprehensive data collection aimed to support the fellowship programs' daily operations and

strategic planning and provide NIMH with essential information for policy decisions. Data collection involved distributing mail-in questionnaires to fellows, nonfellows, and department heads from institutions with MFP fellows. Carl A. Scott and Richard Lodge from CSWE completed additional questionnaires focused on the operation and effect of the programs within CSWE (Lodge, 1977; Scott, 1976). This evaluation covered the first three cohorts from 1974–1977, with CSWE data focusing on the last two due to the timeline of their first MFP cohort discussed earlier.

The evaluation study highlighted significant demographic disparities among fellows across the five MFPs, particularly in the distribution of Black awardees (Penick, 1978). The APA selected a higher proportion of Black awardees than the number of applicants, unlike the CSWE, which selected fewer, potentially due to a quota system leading to a higher ratio of unfunded to funded Black applicants. The fewer Black applicants and fellows in the mid-1970s can be partly explained by the scarcity of social work doctoral programs at that time, which likely reduced the likelihood of Black students applying and being selected for the MFP. Furthermore, it was not until 1976 that Howard University and 1983 Clark Atlanta University, both historically Black colleges and universities (HBCUs), established their social work doctoral programs (Carten, 2021; Hopps et al., 2021). The presence of doctoral programs at HBCUs would have likely increased the number of eligible Black student MFP applicants.

Furthermore, initial cohorts of MFP fellows predominantly attended elite Research 1 universities such as Berkeley, Columbia, and the University of Michigan. This trend may be attributed to the few social work doctoral programs available in the mid-1970s, primarily situated in prestigious institutions (Kendall, 2002; Lee et al., 2023; Patchner, 1982). Consequently, becoming an MFP fellow during that era typically meant enrolling at one of these elite universities. Notably, half of the current social work doctoral programs were established after 1976, highlighting the scarcity of such programs in the mid-1970s (Acquavita & Tice, 2015; Austin, 1997; Dinerman et al., 1984). Age demographics also varied, with fellows from the APSA and the ASA being significantly younger than those from the ANA and CSWE. This age difference influenced the professional backgrounds of the fellows; CSWE fellows, often older, generally had more extensive professional experience than younger APA fellows. This trend correlates with the requirements of many social work schools that stipulate professional experience for admission to doctoral programs, suggesting that age and professional experience are interrelated factors in fellowship selections (Penick, 1978).

The evaluation of the MFP outcomes highlighted several critical aspects, including cost-effectiveness, effect on minority enrollment, departmental characteristics, and training quality (Penick, 1978). The evaluation revealed that the CSWE MFP was less cost-effective than other NIMH programs, costing \$6,011 per student per year, below the NIMH average of \$6,900. Despite lower costs, the CSWE MFP faced criticism for high operational expenses and lacked features like internships and newsletters, unlike the ANA program. Departments with APSA fellows saw a 25% increase in minority enrollment, while those with CSWE fellows experienced less significant growth, suggesting limited effectiveness in enhancing diversity. Despite access to extensive resources, CSWE fellows often felt isolated in large departments. Nonetheless, the CSWE improved training quality with workshops, publications, and diversity-focused accreditation criteria, reflecting a proactive approach to minority mental health education (Penick, 1978).

The CSWE provided qualitative insights on their MFP, discussing its goals, achievements, and challenges. For short-term goals, the MFP aimed to support committed ethnic minority individuals in pursuing doctoral social work education by offering fellowships, increasing educational choices, and facilitating the transition from work to doctoral studies. Long term, the program sought to develop a cadre of ethnic minority researchers dedicated to community service and knowledge improvement in their fields. In its first two years, the MFP awarded 30 fellowships, with recipients ranking in the top 10% of their classes, bolstering social work schools' efforts to recruit, retain, and use ethnic minority students (Lodge, 1977; Scott, 1976). Challenges included inadequate funding for unforeseen needs like moving expenses and library fees for part-time students, as well as providing sufficient dissertation phase support. The CSWE reported that awardees viewed the MFP positively, valuing the career advancement it enabled, although they

desired more networking opportunities. The CSWE promoted the MFP in its “Social Work Education Reporter” newsletter and encouraged fellow participation in CSWE Annual Program Meetings to enhance visibility (Lodge, 1977; Scott, 1976).

Conclusion

Exploring the early formation of the CSWE MFP provides a valuable historical perspective on initiatives to foster diversity and inclusion within social work education. Drawing from archival CSWE documents and broader historical records, this historical narrative illuminates the concerted efforts during a critical period in social work history. It highlights CSWE’s strategic moves to address systemic barriers and promote equitable opportunities in educational settings, responding to the needs of racially and ethnically diverse communities. This article traces the foundational steps leading to the establishment of the MFP and contextualizes it within broader social movements and the evolving dialog on inclusion and diversity in academia and professional fields.

As we commemorate the 50th anniversary of the CSWE MFP Research Fellowship, it is essential to acknowledge the program’s effect on enhancing the professional landscape for minority social workers. By supporting the educational and professional development of numerous social workers from minority backgrounds, the MFP has played a pivotal role in enriching the profession with diverse perspectives and competencies. This strengthens the profession’s responsiveness to multicultural populations and enhances the overall quality of social work practice. Looking forward, the legacy of the MFP offers both inspiration and a framework for ongoing efforts to enhance diversity in social work and other professional fields. It serves as a reminder of the importance of continued advocacy, policy innovation, and community engagement in promoting inclusivity.

As this article contributes to the historical record of the MFP, it also sets the stage for future initiatives that will continue to drive the program’s mission, ensuring that it remains a transformative element in racially and ethnically diverse social workers’ education and professional development. In doing so, the MFP will continue to meet the evolving needs of communities of color, embodying the ideals of equity and justice central to the social work profession. In our follow-up article, we will resume our discussion with the 1978–1979 MFP year, continuing with the fourth CSWE MFP Research Fellowship cohort, and introducing the first CSWE MFP Clinical Fellowship cohort. The article will be titled, “Origins of Opportunity, Part 2: The Introduction of CSWE’s Minority Fellowship Program Clinical Fellowship, 1978–1992.”

Reflection

Each author of this article is a CSWE MFP alumnus with tenures ranging from the program’s inception to the present. Dr. E. Aracelis Francis, who was a project associate on the CSWE Black Task Force and served on the CSWE Commission on Minority Groups when the CSWE MFP formed, was the director of the program from 1986 until her retirement in 2007. Dr. Francis succeeded the inaugural director, Dr. Carl A. Scott. Dr. Jerome H. Schiele was a doctoral fellow from 1986 to 1989 under Director Francis. Drs. Justin S. Harty and Autumn Asher BlackDeer shared the same doctoral cohort from 2019 to 2022, while Durrell M. Washington, soon to be Dr. Washington, began his fellowship in 2021, which concludes in 2024. Dr. Harty, supported by the CSWE MFP network, received mentorship from Dr. Schiele, assigned by then-Director Duy Nguyen, and support from fellow MFP alumni Dr. Waldo E. Johnson, Jr., and Gina E. Miranda Samuels. As scholars at various stages of our careers—from emerging to senior and emeritus—we pay tribute to the lasting effect of the MFP’s founders, fellows, and staff. We express profound gratitude for their enduring legacy and significant contributions to the social work profession, which have been instrumental in shaping a more diverse and inclusive social work education and practice to meet the needs of racially and ethnically diverse populations.

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